

The Diversities of Tongues

The Spirit, the Lord, and the Father Work Together in Gifts and Offices

Now concerning spiritual gifts, brethren, I would not have you ignorant.

Ye know that ye were Gentiles,
carried away unto these dumb idols,
even as ye were led.
Wherefore I give you to understand,
that no man speaking by the Spirit of God calleth Jesus accursed:
and that no man can say that Jesus is the Lord,
but by the Holy Ghost.

A man cannot be speaking by the Holy Spirit and deny Jesus. I do not care what religion he claims to be part of. If he denies the deity of Jesus, he cannot be speaking by the Holy Spirit. And no man can say Jesus is Lord but by the Holy Ghost. Unless he is born of the Spirit, he cannot even call Jesus Lord.

Now look at what we are majoring on:

Now there are diversities of gifts,
but the same Spirit.
And there are differences of administrations,
but the same Lord.
And there are diversities of operations,
but it is the same God which worketh all in all.

In essence, what he is saying is this, and I do not have time to major on it. There are diversities of gifts, but the same Spirit. How many know that the gifts work by the Holy Spirit? The gifts are of the Holy Spirit.

Then there are differences of administrations. Another Greek word for "administrations" is gifts. There are different gifts placed in the body, that is to say, offices. These are the same offices Jesus placed when He ascended on high, led captivity captive, and gave gifts unto men.

The Holy Spirit gives the gifts. He empowers the gifts. Jesus puts the offices in the body of Christ. But Paul says it is God who works all in all.

What is he saying? Jesus places the offices. The Holy Spirit supplies the gifts. But it is God who works all the gifts in all the offices.

Specific gifts usually go with specific offices. Some pastors have gifts operating. You know that. But certain gifts are more common with certain offices. Whatever gifts work in whatever offices, it is the Holy Spirit who works the gifts, Jesus who places the office, and God who works all the gifts in the specific offices as He wills.

This is interesting because then he outlines the gifts:

But the manifestation of the Spirit is given to every man to profit withal.
For to one is given by the Spirit the word of wisdom;
to another the word of knowledge by the same Spirit;
To another faith by the same Spirit;
to another the gifts of healing by the same Spirit;
To another the working of miracles;
to another prophecy;
to another discerning of spirits;
to another divers kinds of tongues;
to another the interpretation of tongues.

Now back up to "divers kinds of tongues." The word "divers" means diversities, differences, or different operations of tongues.

Confusion Comes From Putting One Set of Rules on Every Operation of Tongues

The reason the church world is so confused over the diversities of tongues is because we generally try to clump the same set of rules onto all the different operations of tongues. To do that will cause mass confusion. You will absolutely get people confused.

In fact, as representatives of God, you will get the world so confused that they do not even want what you have. That comes from misusing the gifts of the Holy Spirit.

We try to put the same set of rules on the diversities of tongues, or the different operations of tongues. But you cannot do that.

Let me outline the four basic operations of tongues. There are even variations from these, but these are the four basics.

Tongues for Personal Edification Builds the Believer's Spirit

The first diversity of tongues is tongues for personal edification.

That is the one a believer generally receives when he is filled with the Holy Ghost. Many times people have been filled up here, even in this room, and we will say, "Speak it out. Speak it out." Pretty soon their chin starts trembling, their tongue goes wild, their mouth starts shaping words, and pretty soon they go:

"You got it. You got it."

What did they receive? Generally, they received the most basic operation of tongues, tongues for personal edification. It is the one that has been given to them by God for their own personal edification.

Tongues With Interpretation Edifies the Assembly

The second diversity or operation of tongues is tongues that presents itself in a public assembly for the sole purpose of interpretation.

It is tongues for interpretation, and it serves for the edification, exhortation, and comfort of the body. Tongues for interpretation is different from tongues for personal edification.

Tongues Can Empower the Groanings of Intercession

The third diversity of tongues is tongues that comes up from inside a believer and extends itself into the deep intercessional groanings of the Spirit.

This is tongues that empowers a believer for the groanings of intercession.

Tonight, Lord willing, depending on how far we get, we are going to study the difference between the one that edifies me and the one that empowers me for the deep intercessional groanings of the Spirit.

I know that you know what an intercessor is. An intercessor basically stands in the gap. He is a man or woman the Holy Spirit has been able to place between hell and people who are trying their best to get there. There is just one problem: you are in the way.

It would behoove a man to learn the difference between these two operations.

Tongues as a Sign Supernaturally Speaks the Hearer's Language

The fourth basic empowerment of tongues is tongues that empowers a believer and presents itself as a sign to the unbeliever.

Wherever I go, I hear preachers talk about this one:

"We just go ahead and speak in tongues right in front of the sinner. We do it all the time right in front of the sinner. After all, are not tongues a sign to the unbeliever?"

Sure. To him, it is a sign that you are mad. It is a sign all right: that you are mad. That is why Paul said:

Thou verily givest thanks well,
but the other is not edified.

He says the unlearned or the sinner will say you are mad. That is how tongues affect a sinner when they are not presented as a sign to the unbeliever.

When does tongues cross that threshold and present itself as an actual sign to the unbeliever? When it empowers the believer supernaturally to speak any language on the face of this earth or in heaven that the believer had no previous knowledge of.

I have preached in German, French, Arabic, and Spanish. If you ask me how to speak any of them, I can say a few words. "Si, senior." "No comprende." I can say a few things like, "No speak English," or "No speak German." Is that what that means?

If you ask me how many languages I can speak, I would say I used to get letters all the time from English teachers and majors asking me if I would like any kind of help. I like to say it real good. But when I know what I am talking about, I can eventually get it said anyway.

I do not speak any language other than English. None. I would like to.

Yet when the Holy Spirit comes upon you in this particular diversity of tongues, He can empower your spirit, and it will come rolling out of you in the most perfect accented and grammatically correct language that could possibly be spoken.

Brother, when you stand up there and start preaching in German to a bunch of Germans, or in French to a bunch of French people, you get their attention. At that point, tongues has diversified itself into a sign to the unbeliever, because you are telling him about Jesus like nobody has ever told him about Jesus.

Carnality Misuses Spiritual Things Because It Does Not Understand the Spirit

Our problem is not understanding the operation of the Spirit. We have clumped these four basic diversities of tongues into one group and put the same set of rules on them. You cannot do that.

Most people do not teach much about them, because they do not have much understanding about the operation of the Spirit. It is hard to understand His operation with your natural mind.

There is only one place that understanding will come from for such peculiar things as standing there, speaking a language in tongues, not even understanding it with your mind, and yet having God diversify it into vast areas of ministry. We do not understand it, and you will not until you get involved with the Holy Spirit.

That is why we have become so carnal about the whole thing. Good Lord, have we messed intercession groups up in the past.

There are people who bark like dogs in intercession.

"Did that barking anointing ever come on you, Brother Roberson?"

No, and it never will. Never will.

A bunch of women invaded some people's home with little plastic machine guns, saying they were going to shoot the devil in the Spirit.

"Bow, bow, bow."

I would not tell you their names if you paid me.

People do funny things when it comes to the Holy Ghost. Funny things that are not even God. But they can pass it off as God because who knows? Sane twentieth-century people, educated people. If you were to work a business deal with them, they are so sharp they make you feel stupid. But when it comes to the things of the Spirit, they do the dumbest things.

"Can you tell us why, Brother Roberson?"

Yes. Yes, I can.

Diversities of Tongues Is the Foundation Under the Other Offices

Go over to the end of this chapter. When Paul is talking about the offices, look at verse 27:

Now ye are the body of Christ,
and members in particular.
And God hath set some in the church,
first apostles,
secondarily prophets,
thirdly teachers,
after that miracles,
then gifts of healings,
helps,
governments,
diversities of tongues.

This is the entire scope, the whole existence of every office and calling in the whole body of Christ. You are going to fit somewhere in here. Every person in this room has been diversified by God to fill one of these offices.

He says God has set some in the church: first apostles, secondarily prophets, thirdly teachers. Is that not interesting? Why would he say first apostles unless the apostle was at the top of the ladder? Progressively, each ministry or office is set in order as a ladder. First apostles, then prophets, and thirdly He placed teachers in the body.

Can you imagine a teacher? I am talking about a God-anointed teacher of revelation knowledge, one of those men who are drunk on illumination that can only come from the Holy Spirit. They stand up and set your liberty in order, because they tell you the truth, and it makes you so free you can hardly stand yourself.

No wonder it is apostle, then prophet, then teachers third on the list, which also covers the office of pastor.

Look at the lineup. You are in here somewhere. God set some in the church: apostles, secondarily prophets, thirdly teachers. After that, miracles. There are whole ministries of evangelism, pastoring, and teaching set in the body that have this gift of miracles.

Kathryn Kuhlman was one. So was William Branham. Kathryn Kuhlman was a walking office of miracles. Nobody ever packed Mabee Center here like she did. Mabee Center was wall to wall, and there were three thousand people out in the parking lot who could not get in. You want to talk about miracles? She was a walking office of miracles. It was tremendous.

Where do you fit?

He said miracles, then gifts of healings, helps, governments. But I want you to notice what is on the bottom of the list, which every saint can have. If we have not found you yet, you must be contained in the last little office.

What is the absolute bottom of the list? Diversities of tongues.

Now tell me: what is a foundation? What is a foundation to any building? The foundation is the slab. It is whatever you pour that is going to hold that building for the rest of its life.

I want you to notice the foundation that is put under all the rest of the offices. What did he call it? The different operations of tongues.

It is the basic empowerment, the basic operation of the Spirit that all the other gifts and offices spring forth from. What was the first one you got when you entered into the body of Christ?

"I have been born again. What is next?"

The infilling of the Holy Spirit. Speak it out. You have received the foundation, the power that will enable you to diversify into every other office He has called you into.

The diversities of tongues empower the whole operation of the gifts of the Spirit and the gifts placed in the body.

I do not mind telling you, that really makes me excited. He called it the diversities of tongues.

Personal Edification Works in the Same Place Where the Gifts Flow

If we are going to look at two of these, we will look at the difference between tongues for the deep intercessional groanings of the Spirit and tongues for the personal edification of Dave Roberson.

Let us take tongues for personal edification first. The part of me it edifies is my spirit. It edifies the very part of me through which all the rest of the gifts of the Spirit work: workings of miracles, words of wisdom, words of knowledge, prophecy, interpretation, and the others.

Tongues for personal edification is the one that affects my spirit. No wonder God can build the rest of my building on that foundational gift.

It makes me feel like stopping right now.

"Would you all excuse me for a couple of hours? Go ahead and wait. You want to see what happens when we come out of it, do you not?"

Tongues for personal edification affects my spirit. It affects me.

Here is something very interesting. People have accused me:

"What do you think you do, Brother Roberson? Do you control God?"

I said, "No."

"Then what makes you think you can speak in tongues anytime you want to?"

"I do not know. When I open my mouth, it comes out."

"Well, some of it is of you, and some of it is of God."

No. When I speak with tongues, it is all of God.

"You mean to tell me, Brother Roberson, that you can actually speak in tongues anytime you want to?"

Well, I do not do it when I do not want to.

We need to think about this.

"Do you operate the workings of miracles when you want to?"

No.

"Do you operate tongues when you want to?"

Yes.

"Then why do you not just do miracles?"

If I could, I would. I would not be down here. I would be up in the room.

"Do you operate healings anytime you want to?"

No, I wish I could.

"How about the word of wisdom?"

I wish I could.

"How about the word of knowledge?"

I double wish I could. I would tell you all kinds of things all the time.

All the other eight gifts and the other three diversities of tongues do not operate at my will. The Spirit operates those severally as He wills. However, I can stand up here and open my ground up.

When I say "open my ground," what do I mean? I mean I start shutting down. I shut my senses down. I turn my spirit up. I have learned to do that through years of praying in tongues. That is where edification begins to affect a man.

I know how to shut down and open my ground up. I open my spirit. At that point, when He begins to come on me, I am open. If He wants to move through me and do anything for any of you, I am open. Most of the time He will move, but sometimes He does not. I do not control it.

But there has never been a time when I wanted to open my mouth and speak in tongues and could not. I could even jump up and interrupt a service if I wanted to. Many of you have proved that.

"Well then it would not be God."

No, it is God.

"Then you are telling me you control God."

They almost stoned me in Cleveland, Tennessee. That was headquarters for a certain church. All I did was say, "I can speak with tongues anytime I want to," and they looked like they wanted to pick up rocks and hit me.

They said, "The only time I can speak in tongues is when the Holy Spirit is moving really heavily over the crowd. He is moving, and I start crying, and then here they come."

I said, "Wait a minute. The only time you can pray in tongues is when the Holy Spirit is moving on you really heavily and it breaks out of you? You cannot get down on your knees and pray when you want to?"

"No."

"Only when you are crying and emotional?"

"Yes."

"Then if I beat you up with a hammer, could you pray in tongues?"

They wanted to stone me.

I had to ask God, "Now wait. I can speak with tongues anytime I want. How many others can?"

Raise your hand.

Yet we can still interrupt a service with it. I said, "Lord, how can we do that?"

The Believer Is Steward of Tongues for Personal Edification

Paul says if the unlearned is in your midst, and you give thanks with tongues, you are giving thanks well, but the other is not edified. In fact, if you misuse it, they will think you are mad.

How could you give thanks very well, and still be out of order? Because the empowerment is entrusted to you by God.

You do not turn God on and off. Nobody turns Him on and off. I do not control God, yet I can speak with tongues anytime I want. How can this be?

God made you the steward of the language of tongues for personal edification. He made you the steward of it. That is why you can pray in tongues anytime you want. You are the steward of its operation.

The reason is that all the other gifts of the Spirit, all eight and the other three diversities, flow through me outwardly for the edification of others. But that one-fourth, that diversity of the last gift, flows from God through me inwardly for the edification of myself.

Because all the other eight and three-quarters edify other people, and that one-fourth of the diversity edifies me, He made me the steward of its operation so Dave Roberson can be edified as much as he wants, as long as he wants, at his own will, to build me up into the operation of all the other gifts.

Hallelujah.

Tongues for personal edification can be activated by me. All the other offices and gifts spring forth from this foundational gift, the diversities of tongues.

If you think I do not give myself over to something I know will finally edify me in the place where I am so hungry to understand God, then you do not know me. I have had so much carnal head knowledge fed at me, how to do this and how to do that, that I finally had to let go of some of it. So much was coming in that my head got too fat. It was not big enough to hold all of it.

I had to go back and review all the steps of faith I took to receive, in case I made a little mistake somewhere along the line.

I am hungry to know God. Yet I have found something that is foundational. I have found something that affects me, something that charges me up like a battery, something that operates in the part of me where the understanding of God springs forth.

He said:

Ye have an unction from the Holy One,
and ye know all things.

And:

The anointing which ye have received of him abideth in you,
and ye need not that any man teach you:
but as the same anointing teacheth you of all things,
and is truth,
and is no lie.

Listen to me. I can only give you so much. I can fill your head like my head was filled, but you will never really begin to operate in the power of the Word until that anointing which cannot lie grabs hold of the eternity, the life, the illumination, and the Spirit that is in that Word, and causes it to come alive in you.

Jesus said He would send another Comforter. He is the Holy Ghost, and His charge, His commission, is to guide me into all truth. In John 17, Jesus said, "Thy word is truth."

How high a commodity can a man put on truth? If I were ever to have the horriblest nightmare, it would be that some man came along with a damnable doctrine and put me in a holding tank where I spun my wheels in fruitlessness until I lived my life out and finally stood before Jesus stripped of any reward I might have had.

If I ever had that kind of nightmare, that would be the nightmare.

But Satan is the master of deception. In light of the fact that there are tens of thousands of man-made doctrines and only one Holy Spirit, who is right?

The Holy Spirit, of course.

If He is right, and the commission of the Spirit is to guide Dave Roberson into all truth, then there has to be a way, an ironclad, on-purpose, devil-stomping, mountain-moving way, that the Holy Spirit gets involved with my spirit to take the counsel I need to walk by and cause the understanding of the Word to spring forth into my mind, illuminate me, and light me up.

There has to be a way. And there is.

Concerning them that seduce you, John said:

Ye have an anointing which cannot lie.

And this anointing teaches you all things.

What in God's green earth do you think He is talking about when He says that when you pray in an unknown tongue, you edify or charge yourself up like a battery? Why would He say that if this manifestation of the diversity of the Spirit, this tongues for edification that you can activate at your own will anytime you want to, was not designed to enhance that anointing which cannot lie?

Edification means "anointed to understand."

"Roberson, are you going to pray in tongues?"

Yes, because I am fascinated by the fact that I am the steward of my own edification. I am the steward of this fourth diversity of tongues, tongues for edification.

This means I do not have to wonder anymore whether I can be anointed. I do not have to wonder what I am doing wrong. I do not have to wonder what the power is. I do not have to wonder how to develop the power. I do not have to wonder about any of it, because I am the steward of my own edification.

Praying in Tongues Carried Him Out of Religious Exhaustion

Zeal was never my problem. Anybody who promised me God would use me if I partook of their religious beliefs had me on them faster than a fly on sticky paper.

"Give it to me."

They would give it to me, and I mean they would give it to me. By thirty years old, I was worn out, exhausted by religion, tired of forms. I had explored dead-end doctrines and ended up in the same place: powerless, but still so hungry for God that it was hard for me to live with myself, much less ask my wife to.

When I finally got brave enough to go full-time, it was because of a visitation. God had visited me in the night with a vision. I woke up under the anointing, looking at it.

In the vision, I was in a meeting where miracles were flowing like water. Only there was a young woman up there performing the miracles. After she was done, she looked at me and said, "One of you men must have failed. That is why God has given me this ministry."

She looked right at me.

I quit my job immediately. I might be slow, but I am not that slow.

There I was, launching out full-time. I did not know what to do. We had rent and food bills to pay and three little kids to feed. I did not know what to do.

I was real holiness. In fact, if you came to our church and you were a woman wearing pants, that really upset me. I was protecting God. Really upset me.

I did not want to see any women come to my church in pants. I would rather see them stay out and go to hell, but they were not coming in here in pants.

That is what religion does to you.

Is that the issue? Is that what is important? No. It is religion.

I did not know what to do, so I went down to the prayer closet. Of course, I started out in English because we knew how to pray.

Since then, I have found out that if a man prays that way, it is almost an automatic ticket that he is not going to get anything:

"Oh God."

Forget it. Pray that way enough to sound good to other people, and after a while you do not care whether God hears you or not. He never answered the last fifty, so why should it matter whether He answers this one? Pretty soon you just want to sound better than the rest of the preachers when they pray.

He is not hearing anything but your heart anyway. If you are mad at Him, you might as well tell Him, "You have not answered the last fifty prayers, and I want to know why." He will talk to you quicker than if you work around the problem.

What do you think He is, anyway?

I did not know what to do, so I was walking back and forth:

"Oh God. Oh God."

Finally, after fifteen or twenty minutes, I ran out of English. I still had a whole working day to go, because I figured if I prayed all day, or at least stayed down there in the prayer closet, He would pay me. I had seven and a half hours to go, and I was already out.

God is my witness: I switched to praying in tongues only to survive my commitment.

I was afraid of God. I was afraid that if I fell short of my commitment, He might take it out on one of my kids or something. After all, that is what they told me. He would get my money. He would get even somehow. So I was afraid, and I stayed in there.

But I switched to praying with tongues not because I knew what it would do, but just to survive the hours I had committed to.

Let me tell you something. A thousand miles of wrong doctrine, a hundred miles of the Word that had already been fed into me in a wrong light, began to break. When that anointing began to take hold of me after three months, I became anointed to understand. I took my first step out of bondage, and I have been walking out of it ever since.

You might as well give Him a hand. Hallelujah.

He is worthy.

Anointed to understand. The steward of my own edification.

Hallelujah.

Intercessional Groanings Are Not Activated at the Believer's Will

The other diversity of the gift is the deep intercessional groanings of the Spirit that empower you to stand in the gap.

With that one, I do not operate it at my own will. I have already tried.

"Oh, the lost."

But I can still pray in tongues.

"Oh, me, the lost. I have ten more minutes."

The deep intercessional groanings that empower you to stand in the gap for the lost are not activated by your own will. That is not a diversity of tongues you activate by your own will. You are not the steward of that one. That one is activated severally as He wills.

Let me tell you a little about that one. It operates out of a heart of compassion, whereas tongues of edification will operate out of a stone-cold heart.

"Well, I have to make myself pray. I just do not feel like it."

Then make yourself pray, because you have taken the first step toward being delivered from a stony, cold heart. That is why He says it is through the Spirit that you mortify the deeds of the body. You have taken your first step out of the cold stoniness.

"It just does not feel like it is accomplishing anything."

You walked by your feelings, and that got you where you were, so why do you not be quiet? It is working. It is working on the root of the problem. It is working on the power plant. It is working down on the inside of you, where the spiritual power comes from to mortify the deeds of the body.

I double-dog guarantee you it is working.

Edification Keeps the Believer in the Love That Can Stand in the Gap

On the other side of the coin, the deep intercessional groanings of the Spirit work out of a heart of compassion. You will not have one foot in the world and one foot in deep intercessional groanings that are standing for the world. You will not.

The thing that excites me so much about praying in tongues at my own will, being the steward of my own gift, is that eventually, even though I cannot make intercession happen, Jude 20 and 21 says:

Building up yourselves on your most holy faith,
praying in the Holy Ghost,
Keep yourselves in the love of God.

That edification will keep you where? In the compassion, in the love of God.

Here is a slight difference. If you were crossing the crosswalk and your four-year-old bolted out ahead of you and was killed right before your eyes, what would you do? Would you step back and say, "Oh my, my four-year-old just got run over by a car and killed. That is too bad. Will you pray about it?"

No. Your groanings and wailings would reach the throne room of heaven itself because your child was lost. God knows that if you could change places with that child in that moment, you would. You would rather be the one who died instead of him.

Spiritually, there is only one force that will get you into a condition where you can look on the world and say:

"God, let me stand in the gap. Let me stand in the gap for my family, for my husband, for my wife, for my children, for my church, for my city. Let me stand in the gap as they go to hell. Place me between hell and these people. Let me stand in the gap."

The only force that will get you to that place of compassion and edification is turning Jesus Christ loose within your heart. That means allowing tongues for personal edification to build you and build you in compassion until you feel at times like you cannot live another day if somebody else is going to go to hell.

Then the wailings and groanings will come out of your spirit.

Look out, devil, because you are going to get them.